

SPECIAL MEETING NOTES - May 27, 2020 - 5:30 PM - via Zoom

Mayor - called meeting to order - 5:34 PM

Roll Call - 7-0

Salute the Flag

Mayor - Approve joint resolution for federal relief? Council approved last week to be addressed to the federal delegation

Motion to support by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Van der Kloot

Member Van der Kloot - How do we sign the letter?

Mayor - My office will handle getting that done

Roll Call - 7-0 - paper passes

Mayor - Finances & Budget - Thank you to CPA Tony Rosselle, Finance Director/Auditor Aleesha Nutley Benjamin & Assistant Superintendent of Finance Kirsteen Patterson, for their attendance tonight. We appreciate that you are all here tonight.

Mayor - In discussions with the Superintendent and Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, we have decided to utilize the Cares Act monies to purchase chromebooks for our students - Whether we go back to in session school, or continue with remote learning, we will need the additional technology.

Ms. Nunley-Benjamin-background on city finances - \$8M funding gap - FY 21 school budget - with wish list - collections are behind - we can not add any more to budget - CARES ACT - not a revenue offset - can't use it for the \$8M deficit - we can not have any additional expenses

Mr. Rosselli - Not unlike any other city in the country - Dire out there - country shut down for 2 months - real estate taxes delayed, penalties and interest are all delayed - What I reported to you previously, Aleesha redid my calculations and came up with the same figures as I did. \$61.2M - that is what administration is to work towards -we really need to focus on that now

Member Ruseau - I beg to differ, the country was not shut down for 2 months - our staff was working through all of this - our billionaires are richer - I'm not attacking you - How we get our

money for public goods shut down - Mayor didn't request a bond from Council to pay for our school budget - this is a false narrative - we have options - we are not addressing the options - we as school committee, haven't been a part of the budget, so why are we here? I'm fine with never voting a rubber stamp budget

Ms. Nunley-Benjamin - we can't legally borrow right now without legislation to offset the deficit - cities and towns have submitted to state - and same with federal - nothing's been done - Mayor has to submit a balanced budget

Mr. Rosselli - point of clarification - there was no grassroots effort - since then - cities and towns have banded together to approach state - put more force behind it - so would benefit everyone - if legislature wants to address it

Member Kreatz - Thank you - we all want what's best for our students - we are one Medford - we are all working together - some families have lost jobs/ have no food - I did speak to Rep Donato - & currently State is debating allowing cities/towns to submit a 1/12 budget - we can't borrow money for a deficit - I make a motion: I want all the wish list items too - But right not feasible. Keep the wish list in a google doc - once we get funding, we can revisit the list and where we are financially, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Member Graham - I want to be clear. The wish list was born out of emotion from this committee to increase student achievement - I don't consider all of these items a wish list - these are necessities - I think we should not throw this list out the window - we might have to say to other things that we have always done, that maybe we can't do some of those anymore. I mean Lessier Core 5, an online literacy program, shouldn't be a wish list. That's short sighted - can we please not call it a wish list for the love of God?

Member McLaughlin - To provide some historical background if I may, back in January, we asked the principals/directors, if there was as much money available for whatever they might need, what would be on your wishlist? They were directed to call it a wish list. They had not had this opportunity in the past. So let us keep an open mind and I'm all for looking over the list, if money becomes available, so that is why I seconded Member Kreatz's motion.

Member Graham - But I don't believe it should be considered a wish list

Member McLaughlin - But that is what we called it then, a wish list

Member Van der Kloot - So there is a motion on the floor to keep the wish list as a google doc for future reference. Additionally, I would like to thank Aleesha for being here and grateful she

is well. We can't ignore that our budget has always had a \$2M deficit - raises, step increases, transportation costs - our extras, the rentals, the revolving accounts, helped to fund that deficit. Those financial sources aren't there. We are aware of the city's rainy day fund - Tony suggested not to touch it. This is unprecedented. Our costs this coming year will be much larger - that is part of the real crisis for the school committee- we need the money we already have plus that for our unprecedented needs. Many, many issues here.

Mayor - We will probably use some of the rainy day fund for public safety.

Member Kreatz - I'm not getting rid of the wish list - right now so many unknowns - Rep Donato hasn't finalized the state budget because of so many unknowns - maybe leave everything on and see where we land - use it in the same style as a school improvement plan style budget?

Member Graham - Questions about the city position to borrow if we are able too? If so, how much? Was it already brought up at the Council?

Mayor - depends on local aid - many unknowns. For example, the sidewalk contract wasn't fully funded. The total cost was \$1M, only \$500,000 was paid.

Member Ruseau - One of the councillors asked, what if they just don't do the sidewalks? I'm not sure he received an answer. What is the last resort? Borrowing or cutting?

Ms. Nunley- Benjamin - As I have said, at this point, borrowing is not an option

Member Ruseau - What is the last resort? Will we still be asked to cut the budget?

Ms. Nunley-Benjamin - As you all are aware, the government is slow, we have no real answers as yet.

Member Ruseau - I want to hear from the Mayor

Mayor - We need to find out what Local Aid and Ch 70 monies will be. We are awaiting the federal government's actions. We are seeing if the State's rainy day fund can be used. Right now, my hope is for state and federal aid. I can't say we'd borrow as it's not legal right now - I have 3 children in the Medford Public Schools. I take offense that you make it sound that I don't want to do the very best for our students. No one wants to make cuts. We all know the needs. This is the worst case scenario. When I took office, there were so many things I had planned to do.

Member Ruseau - I just wanted to know our last option. I didn't want to offend you

Member Van der Kloot - In the end, we may have to do some dirty work. None of us want too, but we may have too. Additionally, there is a motion on the floor ...I would respectfully add, "as funding allows"

Member Kreatz - to Member Ruseau & Mayor - we all want the best for our students - we are all on the same page - prior to the pandemic, the wish list items would have been approved - we can revisit it once we have additional funding - we all want more, everyday, all the time

Mayor - Motion on the floor by Member Kreatz, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Member Ruseau - Things weren't good before - they are awful now - people had 3 and 4 jobs - economy wasn't doing great before

Member McLaughlin - We act as a committee of the whole, a team. We are all parents/grandparents who care about our community - we need to focus on that. We have to hope that our Ch 70 funds stay on track, as the first to feel the cuts are our most vulnerable: our homeless, special education and EL students. We really need to work together during this unprecedented time - as Mr. Plati said in our roundtable; "it's the best of times and the worst of times". We must work together!

Mayor - Motion on the floor - Roll Call Vote please

Roll Call - 7-0 paper passes

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Just so you are all aware, the administration has already begun to really look at our budget ...is there redundancy? As was already stated, we will have to do the dirty work. It's the part of the job that no one wants.

Member Ruseau - It's frustrating that we always start at the end? For example, Natick prior to pandemic asked for an increase in taxes to benefit the school budget. I feel like we have no useful purpose here.

Ms. Patterson - Respectfully, I have to disagree. We do start from the beginning, but COLA's have to be taken into consideration. No we did not have a number we were building towards. We did not know where the cities monies would land, but the budget process and the building process has always been transparent. The department heads have always had the opportunity to present what they needed. But this is an unprecedented fiscal crisis. We aren't the only

department that will feel this. The pain will be felt by the schools and every city department. We have never backed into a number

Member Ruseau - Our budget doesn't go up in leaps and bounds - it actually went down last year. So it is not the truth that the budget goes up every year

Mayor - How do we move forward from here?

Graham - Kirsteen can you clarify, if our number is \$61M - what is the amount we would have added for contract increases and COLA's and transportation?-

Mayor - \$64.3M

Member Graham - \$8M from revolving, correct? - 2 ½ M for increase -\$4.3M cut?

Mayor - Those discussions have to be made with the school administration.

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Right now we are looking at cuts across the board in every department while still awaiting DESE and CDC guidance. As the Mayor has said there are truly so many unknowns, and this was discussed in the roundtables. It is a difficult task. We must meet with each of the unions. We are generating a list where cuts could be made. There is no one, and no one department that is exempt.

Member Graham - We all have different perspectives. Going back to school in September may not really be an option. A robust and clear conversation needs to be had, and can't be done on June 29th.

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - we have our regular meeting on Monday, and a committee of the whole on June 15th. As I've said, we have not engaged all the CBA's yet

Member Van der Kloot - Cares Act money - glad it's going towards technology - will the city use \$5M?

Mayor - Hope to use it for city and school budgets

Ms. Nunley-Benjamin - It can be used for direct Covid 19 purchases - doing my best to get it that list together - but it can't be used to offset the budget, it can only be used for direct covid purchases

Member Graham - I make a motion that equipment and PD be charged as a direct covid expense to improve outcomes for remote learning, and educators need more than a chromebook to manage a classroom, seconded by Member Ruseau

Mayor - A memo regarding the CARES Act will be discussed June 1st

Member Van der Kloot - is this workable to provide us with a plan for June 1st?

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - yes

Roll Call - 7-0 - paper passes

Mayor - A plan from administration will be discussed at the June 1st meeting Thank you to Aleesha, Tony and Kirsteen.

Mayor - motion to adjourn?

Member Graham - What about executive session?

Member Ruseau -I make a motion to go into executive session, seconded by Member McLaughlin

Roll Call 7-0

Mayor - We will enter exec session and then report out - 6:35 PM

Mayor - Thank you for your patience. We made one motion by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Graham to move the 2020-2021 Vision Statement to the Engagement, Communication and Strategic Planning Subcommittee - Roll Call Vote

Roll Call - 7-0 - motion passes

Mayor - Motion to adjourn by Member McLaughlin, seconded by Member Ruseau - Roll Call - 7-0 - motion passes

Meeting adjourned - 7:56 PM